Conditionals types 1, 2 and 3

Goal: To form and use the three types of conditional sentences correctly, and to choose the type that matches how real or unreal the situation is.

The idea in two lines: A conditional sentence has an **if-clause** (the condition) and a **main clause** (the result). The further we move from reality, the further back the tenses go.

Type	If-clause	Main clause
1 · real / likely	present simple	will + base verb
2 · unreal now	past simple	would + base verb
3 · unreal past	past perfect	would have + past participle

Figure 1: The tense pattern of each conditional type.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Type 1** (possible future): If + present simple, will + verb: *If a company cheats, it will lose its customers.*
2. **Type 2** (imaginary present): If + past simple, would + verb. Use *were* for all persons: *If I were a manager, I would fight corruption.*
3. **Type 3** (imaginary past, regret): If + past perfect, would have + V3.
4. **Unless** = if … not: *Unless they pay taxes, they will be fined.*
5. Other modals are possible in the main clause: *can, may, could, might.*
6. A comma follows the if-clause when it comes first; no comma when the main clause comes first.

🟢 Examples

1. Complete: *If the firm (respect) workers' rights, it (gain) their trust.* **Solution:** respects / will gain (type 1).

2. Rewrite: *He accepted the bribe, so he went to prison.* **Solution:** If he **hadn't accepted** the bribe, he **wouldn't have gone** to prison. **Explanation:** past fact, so type 3 with the opposite meaning.
3. Rewrite with *unless*: *If you don't read the contract, you will be cheated.* **Solution:** Unless you read the contract, you will be cheated.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Putting *will* or *would* in the if-clause: *If he will come* is wrong.
- Forgetting to reverse positive and negative when rewriting a real fact as type 3.
- Using *unless … not* together (double negative).
- Writing *would have went* instead of *would have gone*.

🟡 Quick review

- Type 1: present → will.
- Type 2: past → would.
- Type 3: had + V3 → would have + V3.
- Unless = if not; never will in the if-clause.

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